customers, for example, are left out in the cold.

Take the case of my father. He uses Windows Vista Home Premium because he's a power user, but doesn't require all the power of Windows Vista Ultimate. Fortunately for him, all his software work on Vista. But suppose they did not? He'd have had to fork out over Rs 13,000 for Windows 7 Ultimate, now that Windows XP isn't available on the retail shelves. Considering he already has a licence for Windows XP Professional as well, that would have been a huge loss. He might as well ditch Windows 7's better user experience and install Windows XP. Either way, getting XP Mode working requires giving Microsoft quite a bit of money.

Enter, the poor man's XP Mode

In the best case scenario, you use Linux but do have to use Windows for some corporate software (your need could even be as trivial as running your smartphone's PC suite-like software). If you have a licence for Windows XP, it means that you can get XP Mode for free, and cut the hassle of rebooting every time you need to use Windows. As an added advantage, the poor man's XP Mode works on Windows, Mac, OpenSolaris, Linux and even BSDs. And it has the best price one can ask for: it's free!

What can this provide?

- A virtualised copy of Windows XP that can run all your corporate apps, sync your cell phones, run some games (NOT Crysis Warhead; so if you're a serious gamer, don't even think about this) and some niche software, such as desktop publishing and designing software, non-linear video editors and more.
- A seamless environment, where the Windows apps look like they're on the Linux desktop.
- Copy-and-paste between the Linux and the Windows apps.
- File sharing between Linux and Windows—for both read and write
- Accelerated DirectX on the Windows XP desktop.
- All available for Mac, Windows, Linux, OpenSolaris and even BSD. Time to take revenge on Microsoft by making your XP Mode in Windows 7 Starter Edition ;-)

Happy? As for the requirements for this sort of a set-up, here's the list:

- A legitimate copy of Windows XP (Yes, although that 9-in-1 edition of Windows XP that you bought for 50 rupees from that CD-walla at the train station will do fine, the whole point of this article is to have a solution that's completely legal.)
- Sun xVM VirtualBox, PUEL Edition.
- About 10GB of hard disk space to spare.

Assuming you are ready, let's do it!

Step 1: Installing VirtualBox

Sun xVM VirtualBox is a free, partially open source virtual machine software. Here I'll set it up on openSUSE 11.2.

Basically, you need to head to the VirtualBox website (*virtualbox.org*), where you'll see self-contained packages for almost all major Linux distros, plus a generic package for any that's not listed. It's just a matter of downloading these packages and double-clicking them to install VirtualBox. You will need to have Qt4 installed, and you must remove the *virtualbox-ose* package if it's installed. Also, it's a good idea to have the Linux kernel sources, GCC, and Make installed.

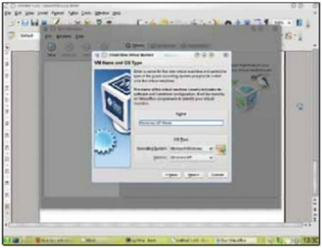

Figure 1: Creating our XP Mode

Having come this far, it's time to add your user name to the *vboxusers* group, so that you get access to the USB system in Windows XP. To do this, open a terminal, and type the following command as the root:

```
usermod -A vboxusers <your username>
```

Depending on whether your distro is hit by this bug or not (openSUSE is), if nothing happens when you start VBox, type in the following:

```
chmod +x /usr/lib/virtualbox/VirtualBox
```

We are now done with this step. So let's create the machine that will run Windows XP.

Step 2: Creating the virtual machine

To open VirtualBox, head to your System Tools group under your applications menu. The first time you start this app, you'll be asked to register it. If you have a Sun Developer Network account (or a Project Kenai ID), then just enter your e-mail and password. Otherwise, you'll have to fill in details about yourself. You can also click *Cancel* and continue, but it's generally a good idea to register your copy.

Now, on the top toolbar, hit *New*. The *Create New Virtual Machine Wizard* will start. Hit *Next*. Now give a name to this virtual machine (as shown in Figure 1), and leave the OS as Windows XP (or Windows XP 64bit if you have a 64bit Windows XP). Click *Next*.

You need to devote some memory to this machine. I have 2 GB of RAM, plus 4 GB of swap space, so I'm going to give XP Mode 1 GB of RAM. If you have the dream 4 GB of RAM, then you'd like to give XP 2 GB, though 1 GB is enough, as XP rarely requires more than 300 MB by itself. Once you are done, click *Next*.